

Think Like a Forest

A 3-day forest retreat that teaches leadership teams to sense in canopies, roots and mycelium instead of orgcharts.

Every module runs three tracks at once.

NARRATIVE

You walked into a forest expecting a metaphor and left with a decision system.

COGNITIVE

Forest ontology: canopy (vision), trunk (structure), roots (values), mycelium (relational intelligence).

IDENTITY

From org-chart holder to canopy-reader.

Why this matters

Slow the body enough for slower thoughts to arrive.

"What did you already know before you walked in?"

01. The Long Arrival

40 min

Land through the body.

Prompt: Walk 40 minutes in silence to the site. No phones.

Debrief: Circle-check: 'What did the walk do to your first sentence?'

02. Root Introduction

20 min

Introduce yourself through what holds you.

Prompt: One-line intro: 'What holds me is ____.' No job titles.

Debrief: Notice what is not said.

03. The Fire Question

25 min

Ask the question you brought.

Prompt: Speak the one question you carried into the forest. Then place a stick on the fire.

Debrief: No responses. The question stays.

The reframe

Break the org-chart lens with a living-system lens.

"What if your team is a canopy, not a hierarchy?"

01. Canopy Mapping

30 min

Look up. Really look up.

Prompt: Spend 30 min in one spot studying the canopy above. Sketch what you see.

Debrief: Ask: 'What role does your team play in your org's canopy?'

02. Mycelium Walk

60 min

Follow the invisible connections.

Prompt: Walk with a guide who points out the mycelial network of one hectare.

Debrief: Ask: 'Where are the mycelial channels in your org?'

03. Deadwood Inventory

30 min

Honor what's decaying productively.

Prompt: Find deadwood in the forest. List what it feeds.

Debrief: Ask: 'What in your org is decaying productively?'

Organize complexity

Turn the forest lens into an org-legible framework.

"What is the shape of your organizational forest?"

01. The Forest Blueprint

60 min

Draw your org as a forest.

Prompt: Draw: canopy (vision), trunks (functions), roots (values), mycelium (relational intelligence), deadwood (legacy).

Debrief: Present to the group. Take questions.

02. Season Overlay

30 min

Assign a forest season to each initiative.

Prompt: Every current initiative gets a season: seed / growth / flower / harvest / decay.

Debrief: Ask: 'Are we planting when we should be harvesting?'

03. Keystone Species

20 min

Identify who cannot leave without collapse.

Prompt: Name 3 keystone people. Name 3 keystone practices.

Debrief: Ask: 'How do we protect the keystones without freezing the forest?'

Pattern discovery

Sit still long enough for the forest to speak back.

"What has the forest been telling you that you weren't hearing?"

01. Sit Spot

60 min

One hour, one place, no output.

Prompt: Choose a spot. Sit for 60 min. Do not journal until the hour is up.

Debrief: Only after: write one paragraph.

02. Council of Trees

45 min

Let others speak as parts of the forest.

Prompt: In circle, each person speaks as a tree, root, animal, or stream about the org.

Debrief: Notice which voice keeps returning.

03. Weather Read

240 min

Track the emotional weather of the group.

Prompt: Hourly: one word for the group's weather. Post to a shared board.

Debrief: End of day: read the weather pattern.

Commitment

Return with one decision the forest helped shape.

"What decision are you carrying back down the mountain?"

01. The Descent Letter

30 min

Write yourself a letter to open Monday.

Prompt: Handwritten letter to open at 9am Monday. Seal it.

Debrief: Trust the forest self more than the Monday self.

02. Keystone Commitment

15 min

Commit to protecting one keystone.

Prompt: Name the keystone and the protection. State it in circle.

Debrief: Witness assigned by the group.

03. Seed Package

5 min

Take one physical seed home.

Prompt: Take one physical seed. Plant it within 7 days. Photo when it sprouts.

Debrief: The sprout is your first status report.

How the arc unfolds.

- | | | | |
|----|--|-------|---|
| 01 | Day 1 — Arrival
6h | Love | <i>Fire of questions lit.</i> |
| 02 | Day 1 evening — Reframe
3h | Magic | <i>Canopy sketch begun.</i> |
| 03 | Day 2 morning — Framework
4h | Calm | <i>Forest blueprint drawn.</i> |
| 04 | Day 2 afternoon — Sensing
5h | Open | <i>Sit spot + council held.</i> |
| 05 | Day 3 — Descent
5h | Free | <i>Descent letter sealed. Seed taken.</i> |

COMMITMENT CONTRACT

"Which keystone will you protect between now and the next equinox?"

Between now and _____ I will protect the keystone of _____ by _____. My witness in the circle is _____.

Witness — One person from the retreat circle.